Of Akbar’s empathy and care for his poorer subjects the Jesuits have left a moving account:

> Amongst his great nobles he was so predominant that none dared lift his head too high; but with the humbler classes he was benevolent and debonair, willingly giving them audience and hearing their petitions. He was pleased to accept their presents, taking them into his hands and holding them to his breast (which he never does with the rich gifts brought to him by his nobles), though often with prudent dissimulation he pretended not to see them.

Many of the rulings from this period of Akbar’s reign reflect this deep empathy, along with a spirit of rationality, questioning all the old traditions and rituals. There was a determined effort, too, to exercise a pragmatic tolerance for practices that would have earlier been condemned by the Padshah. Akbar had been notoriously intransigent, for example, about sexual crimes. ‘The King has such a hatred of debauchery and adultery,’ wrote Monserrate, ‘that neither influence nor entreaties nor the great ransom which was offered would induce him to pardon his chief trade commissioner, who, although he was married, had violently debauched a well-born Brahman girl. The wretch was by the king’s order remorselessly strangled.’ Now, however, Akbar tried to regulate prostitution and set up quarters outside the city, called Shaitanpurah, so that the prostitutes ‘who had gathered together in the Capital in such swarms as to defy counting or numbering’ could be regulated. Nonetheless, the limits of the Padshah’s tolerance may be seen in the order that ‘if a young woman were found running about the lanes and bazars of the town, and while so doing either did not veil herself, or allowed herself to become unveiled, or if a woman was worthless and deceitful and quarrelled with her husband, she was to go to the quarter of the prostitute and take up the profession’.

The selling of alcohol was also now permitted through the opening of a wine shop though it was clarified that the wine was for medicinal purposes. Interestingly, to control boisterous behaviour at the site of the wine shop, a woman, a porter’s wife, was placed there to supervise wine sales, clearly in the belief that men would control their behaviour in the presence of a woman.

Wine had always been drunk, even among the elite. The nobles had their own suchi khanas, or provisioning establishment, which no doubt